

revealed that a keyword letter was aligned to every letter. Interestingly, since Fersen handled all the ciphered communication between the King and Queen during their escape, it is highly probable that Marie Antoinette also had the cipher.

Read between the lines

Only later were the ciphered letters revealed as love letters by Marie Antoinette to Fersen. Apart from ciphers, they also used invisible ink, despite the problems it posed. It has been documented that Marie Antoinette found the invisible ink quite difficult to handle. And between them, they devised an ingenious way to communicate – lines of plaintext in invisible ink embedded between mindless texts in cipher, using the cipher as a guise.

Modern Interpretation

The next major breakthrough emerged only much later, after the invention of the telegraph, which completely altered ancient modes of cryptography. Frenchman Blaise de Vigenere created a very practical method for a polyalphabetic system, named after him. The Vigenere cipher is a simple polyalphabetic substitution method which uses a series of various Caesar ciphers to encrypt a message. This cipher has been reinterpreted many times and while it was easy to understand and put into practice, it was rendered unbreakable by beginners. Thus, it commonly came to be known as the ‘indecipherable cipher’.



Charles Babbage's Analytical Machine

Code Wars

Despite the circuitous and mostly complicated history of cryptography, it wasn't until the 19th century that major advances were made. Cryptanalysis became quite popular and most European states had teams to work on breaking coded messages. Charles Babbage, the creator of the first prototype of the current computers, had done extensive work on mathematical cryptanalysis, especially of pol-